



Gameplan: “After January 2020, the next tournament I played was in October 2021. It didn’t go to plan. I wanted to remain in chess rather than look for a job elsewhere. I started with 2-3 hours of training a day, but destiny wanted me to become a coach,” says Debashis, the first GM from Odisha, who had just completed a camp at the Chola Chess facility in Chennai.

honest, no. I was never inclined towards coaching,” she says. “But I just couldn’t get out of chess. So, I said, ‘At least let me make myself useful to others.’”

Vijayalakshmi’s story compels us to ask an important question. Earning a GM title is a stellar accomplishment, but does it guarantee a sustained run among the world’s elite chess players, all rated over 2700? **What happens to players who fail to take a further step? Are there enough avenues to sustain a career within the framework?**

“Earlier, in my time, even if you were an IM, you could get job opportunities. Public sector entities like the Railways, public sector banks and subsequently oil companies like Indian Oil Corporation (IOCL), Bharat Petroleum, ONGC and so on, recruited chess players,” Ramesh says.

“But the problem is every company can have only so many players in their fold. Chess players typically don’t retire, unlike physical sports. Subsequent generations did not have the same opportunity and had to explore other avenues,” he adds. The most straightforward

option for the GMs was to become trainers. Ramesh was one of the first to try his luck in this direction. He was 22 when he was chosen to coach the Indian team in the Under-20 Asian Championship. In 2008, Ramesh quit his job with IOCL and moved into full-time coaching. He is now one of India’s most renowned chess coaches and a Dronacharya awardee.

“Nowadays IMs aren’t willing to join organisations like the Railways and work on the side. They are earning more by just four hours of classes in a day,” Thejkumar says. “A one-on-one session with a GM costs anywhere from 50 USD an hour (around INR 5000),” Vijayalakshmi says.

For many top chess talents in India, the Covid-19 pandemic was a turning point in their careers. The dearth of tournaments owing to lockdowns meant many had to find alternate sources of income. One such player was Debashis Das, Odisha’s first GM.

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For Shyam Sundar, coaching grew out of what he had lacked as a player. Financial insecurity meant he could not retain a strong coach for long. “There were days when I used to cry, literally, just because I’d be having so many doubts... But no one to explain it,” he says. “That day, I felt that, in future, no one should feel that.” That conviction led to Chess Thulir, an academy where he has trained players for more than a decade.

Shyam Sundar has also worked as a Second with Indian teams, including the women’s side that won silver at the Hangzhou 2022 Asian Games. The position, however, was vastly different from his experience as a trainer. A Second requires a deep personal connection with the player, and the inputs provided must cater to each individual’s style. It should also be delivered with the right measure at the right time. Too many variations end in a panic situation rather than providing clarity.

Shyam Sundar says he earned around INR 10,000 during his stint in the continental competition, making it another viable avenue for pedigreed chess stars. GMs like Pentala Harikrishna, V. Vishnu Prasanna, B. Adhiban, S. P. Sethuraman, among others, have played a crucial role as Seconds in many international competitions over the years.

Ramesh was also an early participant in another potential career option — live commentary. His inputs behind the mic alongside former women’s world champion Susan Polgar during the 2013 World Chess Championship received rave reviews from the public. This path is no longer restricted to just television channels. IM Tania Sachdev, who was part of the Indian women’s team that won the Chess Olympiad in Budapest in 2024, is among the most well-recognised faces in online chess commentary. Some GMs have also